Project XTC

X-Touch Companion

The Unofficial Guide to the Behringer X-Touch, Bitwig Studio and DrivenByMoss

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Part I - Foundations

Understanding how the X-Touch thinks.

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Chapter 1 - Meet the X-Touch

Why "Project XTC"?

XTC stands for **X-Touch Companion**. This guide is designed to sit alongside the official Behringer, Bitwig and DrivenByMoss documentation, bringing everything together into one practical handbook. If the name raises a knowing smile, that's perfectly fine - but throughout this book, **XTC** always means **X-Touch Companion**.

If you've bought a Behringer X-Touch, you've probably already discovered two things. First, it feels like a serious piece of studio equipment. Second, learning to use it effectively with Bitwig can be surprisingly difficult.

The Behringer manual explains the hardware. Bitwig explains the DAW. DrivenByMoss explains the extension. What has been missing is a guide that explains how all three work together. That is the purpose of Project XTC.

Who This Book Is For

This guide assumes you already know the basics of using a computer and Bitwig Studio. It does **not** assume any previous knowledge of MCU, MIDI protocols or control surfaces. Every important idea is introduced only when it becomes useful.

What the X-Touch Is

The X-Touch is a **hardware control surface**. It does not process audio or replace Bitwig. It provides tactile control over track selection, transport, mixing, **PLUG-IN**, automation and much more.

The Four Principles

1. Bitwig is in charge.
2. The selected track matters.
3. Modes change meanings.
4. Feedback is as important as input.

Before You Continue...

Don't worry about memorising every button yet. In the next chapter we'll take a guided tour of the X-Touch so every control has a name and a purpose before we start using it.

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Chapter 2 - A Tour of the Hardware

Before learning individual features, it's worth becoming familiar with the physical layout of the X-Touch. You don't need to memorise every control. The goal is simply to help you recognise where things are, so later chapters can refer to them naturally.

The Eight Channel Strips

The heart of the X-Touch consists of eight identical channel strips. Each strip includes a motor fader, a touch-sensitive V-Pot with an LED ring, a scribble strip display, and buttons such as **SELECT**, **SOLO**, **MUTE** and **REC**. Because every strip is identical, once you understand one, you understand them all.

The Master Section

To the right of the eight channels is the master section. It includes the master fader and additional navigation controls.

Assignment Buttons

The **TRACK**, **SEND**, **PAN**, **PLUG-IN**, **EQ** and **INSTRUMENT** buttons change what the V-Pots control.

GLOBAL VIEW

The **USER** button in GLOBAL VIEW opens Browser Mode when using DrivenByMoss.

Reality Check

If the number of buttons feels intimidating, remember that you rarely use them all at once.

Before You Continue...

The next chapter introduces the mental model that makes the X-Touch predictable.

Chapter 3 - The Mental Model

Most difficulties people experience with the X-Touch come from thinking of it as a mixer with fixed controls. It isn't. The X-Touch is better understood as a window into Bitwig.

Bitwig Is Always in Charge

The X-Touch follows Bitwig's current state. If Bitwig changes, the controller reflects that change.

Selection Comes First

Before adjusting anything ask: **What is currently selected?** Successful workflows nearly always begin with **SELECT**.

Modes Change Meaning

The same controls perform different jobs in different contexts. Understanding modes is more important than memorising combinations.

Always Read the Feedback

Motor faders, LED rings and scribble strips constantly tell you what Bitwig is doing.

A Simple Workflow

SELECT -> Observe -> Adjust -> Listen

Notice that adjustment comes third, not first.

> **Reality Check**
> If the X-Touch behaves unexpectedly, check the selected track, current mode and scribble strips first.

> **Field Note**
> The best X-Touch users don't memorise hundreds of functions. They ask, "What is Bitwig telling me right now?"

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Chapter 4 - Banks and Channels

One of the first things to understand about the X-Touch is that it always provides **eight physical channel strips**, regardless of how many tracks exist in your Bitwig project.

If your project contains more than eight tracks, the X-Touch simply changes *which* eight tracks are currently under your control. This is where the ideas of **channels** and **banks** become important.

Channels

Each motor fader represents a **channel**.

In the simplest case:

X-Touch	Bitwig
Channel 1	Track 1
Channel 2	Track 2
Channel 3	Track 3
...	...
Channel 8	Track 8

If your project contains eight tracks or fewer, this relationship never changes.

The X-Touch behaves very much like a traditional hardware mixer.

Banks

Once your project grows beyond eight tracks, the controller cannot display every track at once.

Instead, it displays a **bank** of eight consecutive tracks.

The first bank contains:

• Tracks 1–8

The second bank contains:

• Tracks 9–16

The third bank contains:

• Tracks 17–24

and so on.

Changing bank simply changes which group of eight tracks is currently mapped onto the eight physical channel strips.

> **Field Note**
> The hardware never changes.
>
> Only the relationship between the hardware and the Bitwig project changes.

BANK Buttons

The **BANK ■** and **BANK ■** buttons move one complete bank at a time.

For example, if you are currently controlling Tracks 1–8:

• Press **BANK ■** once.
• The scribble strips now display Tracks 9–16.
• The motor faders immediately move to the stored levels for those tracks.

Press **BANK ■** to return to the previous bank.

Watching the motor faders reposition themselves is one of the most satisfying demonstrations of what a motorised control surface can do.

CHANNEL Buttons

The **CHANNEL ■** and **CHANNEL ■** buttons work differently.

Instead of moving by eight tracks, they move by **one track**.

Imagine you are currently controlling:

Fader	Track
1	Track 1
2	Track 2
3	Track 3
4	Track 4
5	Track 5

Fader	Track
6	Track 6
7	Track 7
8	Track 8

Press **CHANNEL ■** once.

Now the mapping becomes:

Fader	Track
1	Track 2
2	Track 3
3	Track 4
4	Track 5
5	Track 6
6	Track 7
7	Track 8
8	Track 9

Every channel shifts along by one track.

This makes it easy to bring a particular track into view without jumping an entire bank.

Reality Check
If a track seems to have "disappeared", it has probably moved outside the currently visible bank.

Use the BANK or CHANNEL buttons to bring it back into view.

Reading the Scribble Strips

Whenever you change bank or channel offset, the scribble strips update immediately.

Experienced users naturally glance at the displays before touching a fader.

This simple habit avoids accidental edits to the wrong track.

Why This Matters

Understanding banks and channels makes the rest of the X-Touch much easier to understand.

Whether you are controlling volume, sends, plug-ins or automation, the same principle always applies:

The X-Touch controls the tracks that are currently visible.

Everything else in the controller builds upon this idea.

Exercise
Create a Bitwig project containing at least twelve tracks.

Use the **BANK ■** and **BANK ■** buttons to move between the first and second banks.

Then experiment with the **CHANNEL ■** button and watch how the scribble strips and motor faders update.

Pay particular attention to which track appears on Channel 1 after each movement.

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Chapter 5 - Modes

The X-Touch is often described as having "lots of buttons". That is true, but it is only half the story.

The more important fact is that many of those buttons do **different jobs at different times**.

Understanding modes is the key to understanding the X-Touch.

Once this idea becomes familiar, the controller feels logical rather than mysterious.

What Is a Mode?

A **mode** changes the meaning of one or more controls.

The physical hardware never changes.

Instead, the X-Touch changes how it interprets your button presses, encoder turns and fader movements.

Think of the controller as speaking several different "languages".

Each mode uses the same hardware to perform a different set of tasks.

> **Field Note**
> A common mistake is to think that every button has exactly one purpose.
>
> On the X-Touch, many controls are intentionally multifunctional.

Figure 5.1 illustrates this idea. Although the hardware remains exactly the same, selecting a different mode changes the *role* of the controls rather than the controls themselves.

::: diagram mode-overview
caption: "Figure 5.1 — The X-Touch uses the same physical controls in many different operating modes."
:::

The Current Mode Is Always Visible

Fortunately, the X-Touch rarely leaves you guessing.

The scribble strips, LEDs and button illumination usually indicate the current operating mode.

Before pressing a control, take a quick look at the feedback the controller is already providing.

Experienced users develop this habit very quickly.

The Primary Modes

DrivenByMoss makes extensive use of the X-Touch's mode system.

The most frequently used modes include:

- TRACK
- SEND
- PAN/SURROUND
- PLUG-IN
- EQ
- INSTRUMENT
- USER

Each mode changes what the rotary encoders control and, in some cases, what appears on the scribble strips.

The important point is that these are **not different layouts of the controller**. They are simply different interpretations of the same hardware.

Throughout the remainder of this book we shall examine each of these modes in detail.

TRACK Mode

TRACK mode is the mode most users spend the majority of their time in.

The controller focuses on the Bitwig tracks themselves.

Typical operations include:

- selecting tracks
- adjusting volume
- muting
- soloing
- recording
- automation

Think of TRACK mode as the controller's "home".

Whenever you become unsure where you are, returning to TRACK mode is often a sensible starting point.

SEND Mode

SEND mode changes the rotary encoders so that they adjust send levels instead of pan.

Instead of controlling the stereo position of each track, the encoders now control how much of the signal is sent to an effects bus such as a reverb or delay.

Exactly which send is being adjusted depends upon the current Bitwig project and the selected send.

> **Reality Check**
> If turning an encoder suddenly changes a reverb or delay send instead of the pan position, the controller is almost certainly in SEND mode.

PAN/SURROUND Mode

PAN/SURROUND mode returns the rotary encoders to controlling the stereo (or surround) position of each track.

For most stereo projects this simply means moving sounds left or right within the mix.

PLUG-IN Mode

PLUG-IN mode is one of the X-Touch's most powerful capabilities.

Rather than controlling the mixer, the encoders are assigned to parameters exposed by the currently selected Bitwig device.

The scribble strips display parameter names, allowing the hardware to become a tactile extension of the software interface.

Later chapters explore this workflow in depth.

INSTRUMENT Mode

INSTRUMENT mode provides direct access to software instrument parameters.

Depending upon the selected Bitwig device, the encoders may control filter cutoff, resonance, envelopes, oscillator settings or many other synthesis controls.

The exact assignments depend entirely upon the instrument currently in focus.

USER Mode

USER mode deserves special attention.

Unlike the other operating modes, USER mode is not tied to a particular mixer function.

DrivenByMoss uses USER mode to expose additional Bitwig features.

For example, pressing **USER** immediately opens Bitwig's Browser. The scribble strips are repurposed to display browser information, allowing sounds and presets to be selected directly from the X-Touch.

> **Field Note**
> Because USER mode is completely software-defined, it is capable of doing far more than its name might suggest.
>
> Many users overlook it at first, yet it quickly becomes one of the most frequently used buttons on the controller.

Modes Are Temporary

Changing mode does not permanently alter the controller.

It simply changes what the controls do **at that moment**.

You are free to move between modes whenever your workflow requires.

The motor faders, scribble strips and LEDs update automatically to reflect the current context.

Thinking in Modes

One of the biggest steps towards mastering the X-Touch is learning to ask a simple question:

"What mode am I in?"

Many apparent "problems" disappear the moment you realise that the controller is behaving exactly as expected—it is simply operating in a different mode.

Once this becomes second nature, the X-Touch feels far less complicated than it first appears.

Exercise
Open any Bitwig project.

Press each of the available mode buttons in turn and observe how the scribble strips, encoder assignments and button illumination change.

Do not try to memorise every function immediately.

Instead, become comfortable with the idea that the X-Touch continually adapts its controls to the task at hand.

Recognising the current mode is far more valuable than memorising individual button assignments.

Chapter 6 - The SELECT Button

The **SELECT** button is arguably the most important button on the X-Touch.

New users often assume that its only purpose is to highlight a track. In fact, SELECT determines **where the controller's attention is focused**. Many of the X-Touch's most powerful features depend upon this simple action.

Once you understand SELECT, the behaviour of Device Mode, Browser Mode and many other functions becomes much easier to understand.

Selecting a Track

Each channel strip has its own **SELECT** button.

Pressing one tells the X-Touch:

"This is the track I want to work with."

Nothing is changed simply by selecting a track.

Instead, you are telling the controller where future actions should take place.

Think of SELECT as moving your attention rather than changing your project.

Field Note
The X-Touch always has a current focus.

Many commands operate on the currently selected track, so selecting the correct track before performing another action quickly becomes second nature.

Focus Rather Than Selection

Although the button is labelled **SELECT**, it is often more helpful to think of it as a **FOCUS** button.

When you select a different track:

• Device Mode follows that track.
• Browser Mode follows that track.
• Plug-in parameters follow that track.

• Instrument controls follow that track.

The selected track becomes the centre of attention for the controller.

This idea of **focus** appears repeatedly throughout the rest of the book.

Watching the Controller Respond

One of the strengths of DrivenByMoss is the excellent feedback it provides.

After pressing a SELECT button you may notice changes to:

- the scribble strips
- encoder assignments
- parameter names
- button illumination
- device information

These are not separate operations.

They are all consequences of changing the controller's focus.

The X-Touch immediately adapts to the newly selected track.

SELECT Comes First

As you become more familiar with the controller, a natural workflow begins to emerge:

1. Select the track.
2. Choose the required mode.
3. Perform the adjustment.

Whether you are controlling a plug-in, adjusting sends or browsing presets, the first step is almost always the same.

Press SELECT.

Reality Check
If the X-Touch appears to be controlling the "wrong" plug-in or instrument, the most likely explanation is that a different track is currently selected.

Before assuming something is broken, check which SELECT button is illuminated.

SELECT and the Motor Faders

A common misunderstanding is that selecting a track should cause the motor faders to move.

They do not.

The motor faders represent the **currently visible bank of channels**.

SELECT changes the controller's focus, not the mixer layout.

This distinction is important.

The faders show **where the tracks are**.

SELECT shows **which one you are working on**.

SELECT in Device Mode

Device Mode always follows the selected track.

Imagine a project containing:

• drums
• bass
• piano
• synthesizer
• vocals

Each track contains different devices.

Simply pressing SELECT on another channel instantly changes which devices the controller is connected to.

The rotary encoders, parameter names and scribble strips all update automatically.

No additional configuration is required.

SELECT in Browser Mode

Browser Mode behaves in exactly the same way.

The currently selected track determines where new devices, presets or samples will be inserted.

This makes SELECT an important part of everyday workflow.

Rather than opening the Browser and then deciding where something should go, experienced users select the destination track first.

Developing Good Habits

The most effective X-Touch users develop a very simple habit:

SELECT* → *Observe* → *Adjust

Notice that adjustment comes last.

First establish the correct focus.

Then observe what the controller is telling you.

Only then make changes.

This small change in thinking prevents many mistakes.

> **Field Note**
> One of the recurring themes throughout this book is that the X-Touch is constantly providing feedback.
>
> The more you learn to observe that feedback before pressing buttons, the more natural the controller becomes.

A Typical Workflow

A common sequence might look like this:

1. Press SELECT on the desired track.
2. Press **PLUG-IN**.
3. Adjust the required parameters.
4. Press **TRACK** to return to mixer control.

Although simple, this workflow is repeated countless times during a typical production session.

It quickly becomes second nature.

The Bigger Picture

At first glance, SELECT appears to be a very ordinary button.

In reality, it sits at the centre of the X-Touch's operating philosophy.

The controller is always asking the same question:

"Which track am I working on?"

The SELECT button provides the answer.

Understanding this idea of **focus** is one of the biggest steps towards mastering the X-Touch.

Exercise
Open a Bitwig project containing several tracks.

Press the SELECT button on each channel strip in turn.

After each selection:

- enter Device Mode
- enter Browser Mode
- observe the scribble strips
- observe the encoder assignments

Notice that the hardware itself never changes.

Only the controller's focus changes.

Once you begin thinking in terms of focus rather than simply selection, many other features of the X-Touch become much easier to understand.